

Diabetic Foot Problems - NIDDK

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Diabetes & Foot Problems - NIDDK Home Health Information Diabetes Diabetes Overview Preventing Diabetes Problems Diabetes & Foot Problems Related Topics English English Espa#241;ol Diabetes & Foot Problems In this section: How can diabetes affect my feet? What can I do to keep my feet healthy? When should I see my health care provider about foot problems? Clinical Trials Foot problems are common in people with diabetes. You might be afraid you'll lose a toe, foot, or leg to diabetes, or know someone who has, but you can lower your chances of having diabetes-related foot problems by taking care of your feet every day. Managing your blood glucose levels, also called blood sugar, can also help keep your feet healthy. How can diabetes affect my feet? Over time, diabetes may cause nerve damage, also called diabetic neuropathy , that can cause tingling and pain, and can make you lose feeling in your feet. When you lose feeling in your feet, you may not feel a pebble inside your sock or a blister on your foot, which can lead to cuts and sores. Cuts and sores can become infected. Diabetes also can lower the amount of blood flow in your feet. Not having enough blood flowing to your legs and feet can make it hard for a sore or an infection to heal. Sometimes, a bad infection never heals. The infection might lead to gangrene . Gangrene and foot ulcers that do not get better with treatment can lead to an amputation of your toe, foot, or part of your leg. A surgeon may perform an amputation to prevent a bad infection from spreading to the rest of your body, and to save your life. Good foot care is very important to prevent s

Check your feet every day You may have foot problems, but feel no pain in your feet. Checking your feet each day will help you spot problems early before they get worse. A good way to remember is to check your feet each evening when you take off your shoes. Also check between your toes. If you have trouble bending over to see your feet, try using a mirror to see them, or ask someone else to look at your feet. Look for problems such as cuts, sores, or red spots swelling or fluid-filled blisters ingrown toenails, in which the edge of your nail grows into your skin corns or calluses, which are spots of rough skin caused by too much rubbing or pressure on the same spot plantar warts, which are flesh-colored growths on the bottom of the feet athlete's foot warm spots If you have certain foot problems that make it more likely you will develop a sore on your foot, your doctor may recommend taking the temperature of the skin on different parts of your feet. A "hot spot" can be the first sign that a blister or an ulcer is starting. Cover a blister, cut, or sore with a bandage. Smooth corns and calluses as explained below. Wash your feet every day Wash your feet with soap in warm, not hot, water. Test the water to make sure it is not too hot. You can use a thermometer (90° to 95° F is safe) or your elbow to test the warmth of the water. Do not soak your feet because your skin will get too dry. After washing and drying your feet, put talcum powder or cornstarch between your toes. Skin between the toes tends to stay moist. Powder will keep the skin dry to help prevent an infection. Smooth corns and calluses gently Thick patches of skin called corns or calluses can grow on the feet. If you have corns or calluses, talk with your foot doctor about the best way to care for these foot problems. If you have nerve damage, these patches can become ulcers. If your doctor tells you to, use a pumice stone to smooth corns and calluses